

- RAG Learning

2.6 US Political Parties

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 2 (Government and Politics of the USA and Comparative Politics)

US politics is dominated by two parties — the **Democrats** and the **Republicans** (the "Grand Old Party") — and has been since the 1850s. The examinable puzzle is that they are simultaneously described as *weak* (they cannot control who runs under their label) and *stronger than ever* (party-line voting is at historic highs). Both are true, and resolving that apparent contradiction is what top-band answers do.

1. Ideologies and coalitions

	Democrats	Republicans
Economy	Progressive taxation; greater federal spending on welfare, education, infrastructure; regulation	Lower taxation and federal spending; deregulation; balanced budgets (rhetorically)
Healthcare	Expanded federal provision — the Affordable Care Act	Market-based provision; opposition to federal mandates
Social issues	Abortion rights, LGBT rights, affirmative action, gun control	Social conservatism, religious liberty claims, gun rights under the Second Amendment
Environment	Regulation and climate action	Scepticism towards federal environmental regulation; energy production
Federalism	Federal action, particularly on civil rights and voting	States' rights; limits on federal power

Coalition	Urban voters, ethnic minorities, younger voters, college-educated professionals, women	Rural and small-town voters, white evangelicals, non-college white voters, older voters
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Exam Tip: Note that the parties' positions on **federalism are tactical rather than principled** — each invokes states' rights when out of federal power. Democrats now invoke state authority on climate and abortion access; Republicans have used federal power against state and city policies they oppose. This is strong evidence that institutional norms have become subordinate to partisan advantage.

2. Why the two-party system is so entrenched

1. **Winner-take-all elections** — single-member plurality districts and the winner-take-all Electoral College mean dispersed support wins nothing. **Duverger's law.**
2. **Strategic incentives** — voters, donors and ambitious candidates all converge on the two viable parties, because supporting a third risks helping the least preferred outcome.
3. **Institutional barriers** — state-by-state ballot access rules with substantial signature thresholds; presidential debate polling thresholds; campaign finance and primary structures built around the two parties.
4. **Absorption** — when a third party shows an issue has traction, a major party adopts a version of its position, capturing the support. Populist and Progressive causes were absorbed this way; more recently Tea Party and Reform concerns.
5. **Primaries** — dissenters can contest for control of an existing party rather than founding a new one, which is far cheaper.

Third parties

They rarely win but can be decisive. **Ross Perot** won around 19 per cent of the popular vote in 1992 and **no electoral votes at all** — the clearest possible demonstration of the system's effect. **Ralph Nader** in Florida in 2000 is widely argued to have split the Democratic vote decisively (the "spoiler effect").

3. Ideological sorting and polarisation

Polarisation — the widening ideological distance between the parties and the disappearance of the overlapping centre ground. In Congress it is measured by the near-absence of members whose voting record falls between the most conservative Democrat and the most liberal Republican — a gap that barely existed in the 1960s.

How it happened

- **Ideological sorting.** Until the 1960s both parties contained substantial internal diversity — conservative southern Democrats and liberal northern Republicans, which made cross-party coalitions routine. Democratic support for civil rights legislation triggered the realignment of the South towards the Republicans, and over decades each party became internally coherent. *Polarisation is therefore partly a result of parties becoming consistent, not of anyone becoming more extreme.*
- **Safe districts and primary dominance.** Where the general election is a formality, the only real threat is a primary challenge from the ideological flank — so legislators are rewarded for purity and punished for compromise.
- **Media fragmentation.** Partisan cable news and social media allow citizens to consume information confirming existing views.
- **Ideological donors and groups** funding primary challenges.
- **Nationalisation of politics**, eroding the local factors that let members build independent identities.

Consequences

- **Legislative gridlock** — the filibuster requires bipartisan majorities that no longer exist, so policy moves through reconciliation and deadline-driven omnibus packages.
- **Displacement to the executive and courts** — where Congress cannot legislate, presidents govern by executive order and disputes are settled by litigation. This transfers authority from the most representative branch to the two least accountable ones.
- **Erosion of norms** — the treatment of judicial nominations, debt-ceiling brinkmanship and shutdowns all reflect willingness to use procedural powers to their maximum. The American

system depends heavily on forbearance, and polarisation removes the incentive for it.

4. Party decline or party renewal?

Evidence of <i>renewal</i> (parties stronger)	Evidence of <i>decline</i> (parties weaker)
Party-line voting in Congress at historic highs	Parties cannot control who runs under their label — primaries allow voters to nominate candidates the leadership opposes
Partisan identification predicts vote choice more reliably than in decades	Candidates build their own organisations and raise their own money
Split-ticket voting has collapsed	No disciplinary equivalent to the UK whip — no deselection power
National committees raise and coordinate unprecedented sums	Insurgent nominations against party establishments (Trump 2016)
Leadership control of the congressional agenda has grown	Powerful factions (the Freedom Caucus) can hold their own leadership hostage in a narrowly divided chamber

Exam Tip: The resolution: parties have become **stronger as ideological identities and weaker as organisations**. "Decline" and "renewal" describe different dimensions rather than contradicting each other. A conclusion that says this, rather than picking a side, is doing the analytical work the question asks for.

5. Party organisation

- **Decentralised** — real power rests with state and local parties and with individual candidates, not a controlling national leadership.

- **National Committees** (DNC, RNC) — fundraising, coordination, data operations and running the national convention; they do *not* select candidates.
- **Congressional campaign committees** — support House and Senate candidates.
- **National Convention** — formally confirms the nominee and adopts the platform, though the outcome is settled beforehand. The **platform is not binding** on the candidate.

6. Realignment

A durable shift in the parties' electoral coalitions. The clearest example is the **South's move from Democratic to Republican dominance**, triggered by Democratic support for civil rights in the 1960s and unfolding over subsequent decades.

The concept is contested because such shifts happen **gradually over decades rather than at a single critical election**, so identifying when a realignment has occurred is a matter of interpretation rather than observation.

7. Factions

In a narrowly divided chamber, an organised bloc can withhold votes and extract concessions from its own leadership — influence disproportionate to its size. The **House Freedom Caucus** is the standard example, having forced concessions from and contributed to the removal of Republican Speakers. On the Democratic side, the progressive caucus plays an analogous if less disruptive role.

Key terms

Term	Definition
GOP	"Grand Old Party" — the Republican Party
Ideological sorting	Conservatives consolidating in one party and liberals in the other, removing internal diversity

Polarisation	Widening ideological distance between the parties; disappearance of the centre
Split-ticket voting	Supporting candidates of different parties for different offices on one ballot
Realignment	A durable shift in the parties' electoral coalitions
Solid South	The historical Democratic dominance of the southern states
Duverger's law	Single-member plurality elections tend to produce two-party systems
Spoiler effect	A third-party candidate splitting the vote and changing which major party wins
Candidate-centred campaigning	Candidates building their own organisations and funding, owing little to the party
Faction	An organised grouping within a party, e.g. the Freedom Caucus

Essential examples

- **Ross Perot 1992** — ~19 per cent of the vote, zero electoral votes.
- **Nader, Florida 2000** — the spoiler effect.
- **Civil rights realignment** — the South's shift from Democratic to Republican.
- **Trump 2016** — an outsider capturing a nomination against the party establishment; parties cannot control their own label.
- **Freedom Caucus** — a faction extracting concessions from its own leadership.
- **Clause-by-clause contrast**: US primaries vs UK central candidate approval — the institutional root of the discipline gap.